

The Blue Hour Exposure Ladder

Pocket cheat sheet. Set f/8 · ISO 100 before the light moves, then walk the shutter down as the sky darkens. You are not chasing exposure — you are descending a staircase you built in advance.

THE LADDER — DOUBLE THE SHUTTER ~EVERY 3 MINUTES

T + 0 MIN1/60s

sun's glow still on the horizon

T + 3 MIN1/30s

T + 6 MIN1/15s

T + 9 MIN1/8s

timer or remote from here down

T + 12 MIN1/4s

T + 15 MIN1/2s

T + 18 MIN1s

T + 21 MIN2s

T + 24 MIN4s

T + 27 MIN8s

sky going black — last call

Meter the brightest part of the sky at sunset to anchor T+0. Timings are approximate — the sky sets the pace, the ladder keeps you honest.

WHITE BALANCE

4000K

honest cobalt

3200K

cinematic teal

AWB

murders the blue → muddy gray

RAW

always — previews tell the truth

SHOOT THE THREE MOMENTS

▶ Early blue — foreground detail

▶ Mid blue — the cobalt itself

▶ Late blue — city as pure signal on black

TRIPOD CONTRACT

▶ 2-sec timer or remote — no finger on the shutter

▶ Stabilization OFF on the tripod

▶ Weigh it down — hang your bag

▶ Electronic shutter (mirrorless, 1–8s range)



Know the exit.

When the sky goes black and the foreground turns to mud, the contract has closed. Pack at the plan's end — operators leave with three deliberate frames.